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AI



OpenAI is practically
giving ChatGPT to the
government for free

OpenAI is poised to undercut rivals like Anthropic and Google in the race to see its AI tools integrated into federal agency workflows.

The AI giant has [reached an agreement](#) with the U.S. General Services Administration (GSA), the government's central purchasing arm, to offer ChatGPT Enterprise to participating federal agencies for just \$1 per agency for the next year.

The partnership comes a day after the [GSA added OpenAI, Google, and Anthropic](#) to a list of approved AI vendors that can offer their services to civilian federal agencies. The companies will see their tools offered via the Multiple Award Schedule (MAS), a federal contracting platform that lets government agencies access AI tools via pre-negotiated contracts so they don't have to negotiate with vendors individually.

It's not clear whether other AI firms are going to offer their services at such a discounted rate, though GSA Federal Acquisition Service commissioner Josh Gruenbaum in a [statement](#) encouraged "other American AI technology companies to follow OpenAI's lead and work with us."

TechCrunch has reached out to Anthropic and Google for more information.

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In addition to access to ChatGPT Enterprise, OpenAI is offering unlimited use of advanced models for an additional 60 days. Federal employees will also have access to a new government user community and tailored introductory training resources to get familiar with OpenAI's tools.

Data security is a top priority for government agencies that are concerned about sensitive information being leaked into model training sets. TechCrunch has asked the GSA for details on how government data is being safeguarded, including whether measures like on-premises or private cloud deployments are being used to enhance security.

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"The government is taking a cautious, security-first approach to AI," a GSA spokesperson told TechCrunch. "This ensures sensitive information remains protected while enabling agencies to benefit from AI-driven efficiencies."

OpenAI’s discount comes a couple of weeks after the Trump administration published its AI Action Plan that seeks to boost data center buildouts and integrate more AI tools into government, among other things. It also follows a Trump executive order that [bans “woke AI”](#) and AI models that aren’t “ideologically neutral” from government contracts.

TechCrunch has reached out to OpenAI to learn more about its GSA partnership and how it will approach Trump’s executive order.

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Rebecca Bellan is a senior reporter at TechCrunch, where she covers Tesla and Elon Musk’s broader empire,...

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OpenAI launches Codex, an AI coding agent, in ChatGPT

Maxwell Zeff — 8:00 AM PDT · May 16, 2025

OpenAI announced on Friday it's launching a research preview of Codex, the company's most capable AI coding agent yet.

Codex is powered by codex-1, a version of the company's [o3 AI reasoning model](#) optimized for software engineering tasks. OpenAI says codex-1 produces "cleaner" code than o3, adheres more precisely to instructions, and will iteratively run tests on its code until passing results are achieved.

The Codex agent runs in a sandboxed, virtual computer in the cloud. By connecting with GitHub, Codex's environment can come preloaded with your code repositories. OpenAI says the AI coding agent will take anywhere from one to 30 minutes to write simple features, fix bugs, answer questions about your codebase, and run tests, among other tasks.

Codex can handle multiple software engineering tasks simultaneously, says OpenAI, and it doesn't limit users from accessing their computer and browser while it's running.

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WHAT USERS SEE WHEN THEY OPEN UP CODEX IMAGE CREDITS:OPENAI

Codex is rolling out starting today to subscribers to ChatGPT Pro, Enterprise, and Team. OpenAI says users will have “generous access” to Codex to start, but in the coming weeks, the company will implement rate limits for the tool. Users will then have the option to purchase additional credits to use Codex, an OpenAI spokesperson tells TechCrunch.

OpenAI plans to expand Codex access to ChatGPT Plus and Edu users soon.

AI tools for software engineers, also known as vibe coders, have surged in popularity in recent months. The CEOs of [Google](#) and [Microsoft](#) claim that roughly 30% of their companies’ code is now written by AI. In February, Anthropic released its own agentic coding tool, [Claude Code](#), and in April, Google updated its AI coding assistant, [Gemini Code Assist](#), with more agentic abilities.



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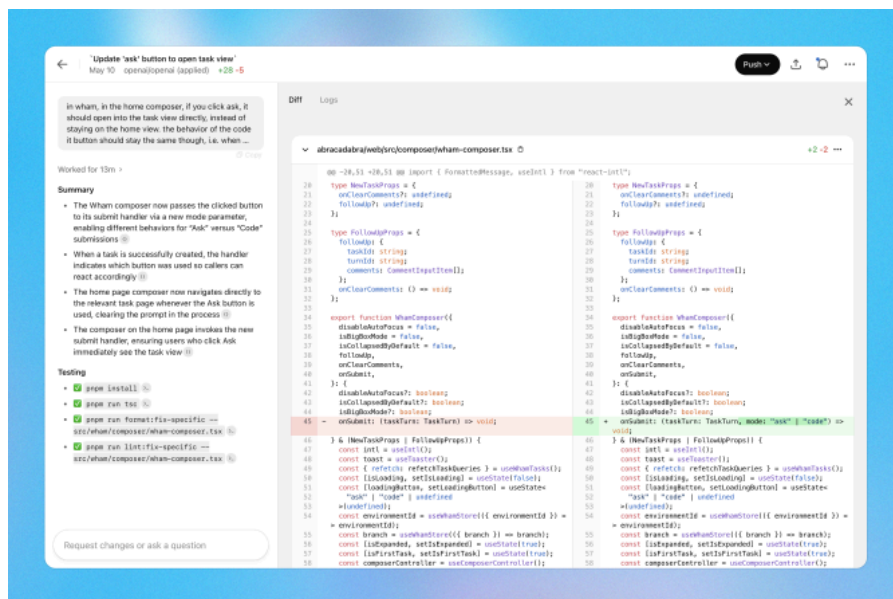
All that vibe coding has made the businesses behind AI coding platforms some of the fastest-growing in tech. Cursor, among the most popular AI coding tools, reached annualized revenue of around [\\$300 million](#) in April and is [reportedly raising new funds at a \\$9 billion valuation](#).

Now, OpenAI wants a piece of the pie. The ChatGPT maker has reportedly [closed on a deal to acquire Windsurf](#), the developer behind another popular AI coding platform, for \$3 billion. The launch of Codex shows very clearly that OpenAI is building out its own AI coding tools, in addition.

Users with access to Codex can find the tool in ChatGPT's sidebar, and assign the agent new coding tasks by typing a prompt and clicking the "Code" button. Users can also ask questions about their codebase and click the "Ask" button. Below the prompting bar, users can see other tasks they've assigned Codex to do, and monitor their progress.

In a briefing ahead of Codex's launch, OpenAI's Agents Research Lead, Josh Tobin, told TechCrunch the company eventually wants its AI coding agents to act as "virtual teammates," completing tasks autonomously that take human engineers "hours or even days" to accomplish. OpenAI claims it's already using Codex internally to offload repetitive

tasks, scaffold new features, and draft documentation.



OPENAI'S NEW CODING AGENT, CODEX IMAGE CREDITS:OPENAI

OpenAI Product Lead Alexander Embiricos says a lot of the safety work for the company's o3 model applies to Codex as well. In a blog post, OpenAI says Codex will reliably refuse requests to develop "malicious software." Furthermore, Codex operates in an air-gapped environment, with no access to the broader internet or external APIs. This limits how dangerous Codex could be in the hands of a bad actor — but it may also hamper its usefulness.

It's worth noting that AI coding agents, much like all generative AI systems today, are prone to mistakes. A [recent study from Microsoft](#) found that industry-leading AI coding models, such as Claude 3.7 Sonnet and o3-mini, struggled to reliably debug software. However, that doesn't seem to be dampening investor excitement in these tools.

OpenAI is also updating [Codex CLI](#), the company's recently launched open source coding agent that runs in your terminal, with a version of its [o4-mini](#) model that's optimized for software engineering. That model is now the default in Codex CLI, and will be available in OpenAI's API for \$1.50 per 1M input tokens (roughly 750,000 words, more than the

entire Lord of the Rings book series) and \$6 per 1M output tokens.

Codex’s launch marks OpenAI’s latest effort to beef up ChatGPT with additional products besides the notorious chatbot. In the past year, OpenAI has added priority access to the company’s AI video platform, [Sora](#), its research agent, [Deep Research](#), as well as its web browsing agent, [Operator](#), as benefits for subscribers.

These offerings could entice more users to sign up for a ChatGPT subscription, and, in the case of Codex specifically, convince existing subscribers to pay OpenAI more money for increased rate limits.

Topics: [AI](#) [ai coding](#) [OpenAI](#)



Maxwell Zeff

Senior AI Reporter |

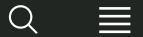
Maxwell Zeff is a senior reporter at TechCrunch specializing in AI. Previously with Gizmodo, Bloomberg,...

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ChatGPT's deep research tool gets a GitHub

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OpenAI is enhancing its AI-powered “deep research” feature with the ability to analyze codebases on GitHub.

On Thursday, OpenAI announced what it's calling the first connector for ChatGPT deep research, the company's tool that searches across the web and other sources to compile thorough research reports on a topic. Now, ChatGPT deep research can link to GitHub (in beta), allowing developers to ask questions about a codebase and engineering documents.

The connector will be available for ChatGPT Plus, Pro, and Team users over the next few days, with Enterprise and Edu support coming soon, according to an OpenAI spokesperson.

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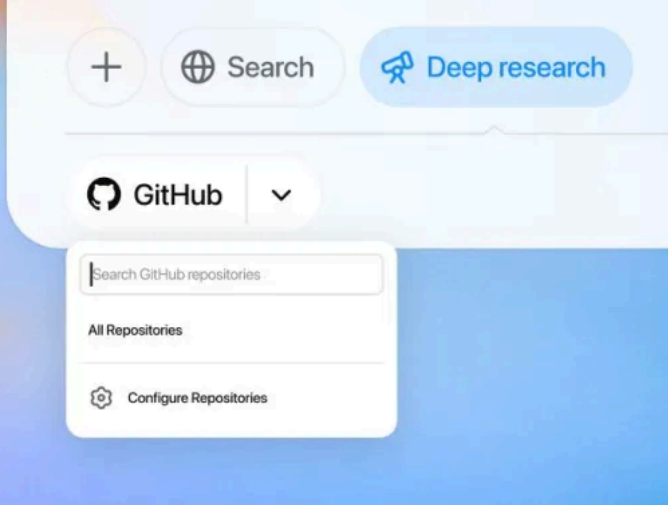
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Google takes on ChatGPT's Study Mode with new 'Guided Learning' tool in Gemini

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OPENAI'S CHATGPT DEEP RESEARCH FEATURE CAN NOW CONNECT TO GITHUB

IMAGE CREDITS:OPENAI

The GitHub connector for ChatGPT deep research arrives as AI companies look to make their AI-powered chatbots more useful by building ways to link them to outside platforms and services. Anthropic, for example, recently debuted [Integrations](#), which gives apps a pipeline into its AI chatbot Claude.

OpenAI [years ago](#) offered a plug-in capability for ChatGPT, but deprecated it in favor of custom chatbots called [GPTs](#).

“I often hear that users find ChatGPT’s deep research agent so valuable that they want it to connect to their internal sources, in addition to the web,” OpenAI Head of Business Products Nate Gonzalez wrote in a [blog post](#) on LinkedIn. “[That’s why] today we’re introducing our first connector.”

In addition to answering questions about codebases, the new ChatGPT deep research GitHub connector lets ChatGPT users break down product specs into technical tasks and dependencies, summarize code structure and patterns, and understand how to implement new APIs using real code examples.

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There's a risk that ChatGPT deep research hallucinates, of course — no AI model in existence doesn't [confidently make things up sometimes](#). But OpenAI is pitching the new capability as a potential time saver, not a replacement for experts.

An OpenAI spokesperson said ChatGPT will respect an organization's settings so users only see GitHub content they're already allowed to view and codebases that've been explicitly shared with ChatGPT.

OpenAI has been [investing](#) in its [tooling](#) for assistive coding, recently unveiling an open source coding tool for terminals called Codex CLI and upgrading the ChatGPT desktop app to read code in a handful of developer-focused coding apps. The company sees programming as a top use case for its models. [Case in point](#), OpenAI has reportedly reached an agreement to buy AI-powered coding assistant Windsurf for \$3 billion.

In other OpenAI news on Thursday, the company launched fine-tuning options for developers looking to customize its newer models for particular applications. Devs can now fine-tune OpenAI's o4-mini "reasoning" model via a technique OpenAI calls reinforcement fine-tuning, which uses task-specific grading to improve the model's performance. Fine-tuning has also rolled out for the company's GPT-4.1 nano model.

Only verified organizations can fine-tune o4-mini, according to OpenAI. GPT-4.1 nano fine-tuning, meanwhile, is available for all paying developers.

OpenAI [began gating](#) certain models and developer features behind verification, which requires organizations to submit an ID and other identity documents, in April. The company claims that it's necessary to prevent abuse.

Topics: [AI](#) [ChatGPT](#) [GitHub](#) [OpenAI](#)



Kyle Wiggers

AI Editor |

Kyle Wiggers was TechCrunch's AI Editor until June 2025. His writing has appeared in VentureBeat and Digital...

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ChatGPT isn't the only chatbot that's gaining users

Kyle Wiggers — 6:00 AM PDT · April 1, 2025

OpenAI's ChatGPT may be the world's most popular chatbot app. But rival services are gaining, according to data from analytics firms Similarweb and Sensor Tower.

IMAGE CREDITS: MALORNY / GETTY IMAGES

Similarweb, which estimates traffic to websites, including chatbot web apps, has recorded healthy recent upticks in usage across bots like [Google's Gemini](#) and [Microsoft's OpenAI-powered Copilot](#). Gemini's web traffic grew to 10.9 million average daily visits worldwide in March, up 7.4% month-over-month, while daily visits to Copilot increased to 2.4 million — up 2.1% from February.

Similarweb reports that [Anthropic's Claude](#) reached 3.3 million average daily visits in March, and Chinese AI lab [DeepSeek's chatbot eclipsed 16.5 million visits](#) that same month. Meanwhile, xAI's Grok, which only gained a web app several

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months ago, averaged the same number of daily web visits as DeepSeek's chatbot: 16.5 million.

The numbers pale in comparison to [ChatGPT](#), which surged past 500 million weekly active users in late March. Yet David Carr, editor at Similarweb, noted that there's fierce competition for the No. 2 chatbot spot.

"[F]or March, DeepSeek is in second place, despite seeing traffic drop 25% from where it was in February, based on daily visits," Carr told TechCrunch. "China's DeepSeek came out of nowhere in January, but the AI platform with the greatest momentum at the moment is Grok from Elon Musk's xAI, with traffic up nearly 800% month-over-month."

AI companies' mobile chatbot apps have been growing their user bases, too, perhaps fueled by recent AI model releases.

According to metrics from app data analysis company Sensor Tower, the Claude app saw a 21% week-over-week increase in weekly active users during the week of February 24, when Anthropic released its latest flagship AI model [Claude 3.7 Sonnet](#). Two weeks prior, shortly after Google made its [Gemini 2.0 Flash](#) model generally available, the number of Gemini app weekly active users grew by 42%.

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Abraham Yousef, senior insights analyst at Sensor Tower, attributed the rising tides not only to new models, but also to new capabilities. [Just this past month](#), Google brought a “canvas” feature to Gemini that lets users preview the output of coding projects, and Anthropic has steadily added [tools](#) to its Claude client.

“The rollout of popular new AI models, heightened consumer interest in the space, the introduction of various new features and functions, and the growing number of unique use cases has propelled user growth for AI chatbot apps,” Yousef told TechCrunch.

But OpenAI probably isn’t panicking yet. Yousef pointed out that ChatGPT had 10x mobile app weekly active users compared to Gemini and Claude combined as of March.

Topics: [AI](#) [Anthropic](#) [Apps](#) [ChatGPT](#) [Claude](#)

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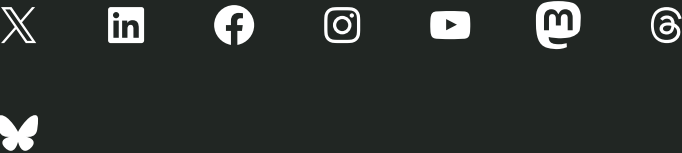
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Kyle Wiggers was TechCrunch’s AI Editor until June 2025.
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